

Constructing the Nation: Identity and Historical Narratives in South Korean History Textbooks

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Abstract

Schools are where states teach the nation, yet the institutions shaping that instruction vary. Regime type and the arrangements governing textbook authorship may both be reflected in national narratives, but they need not change together. This article separates the two through the first full-corpus computational analysis of South Korea’s national history (*kuksa*) textbooks. We analyze all 67 volumes published between 1895 and 2016. Using large language models, we identify identity terms inductively from the corpus and track their meanings with sentence-level embeddings, capturing changes in both vocabulary and context. We find that regime type shows in the character of narrative change, while textbook production institutions set its timing and scale. Under authoritarian state monopoly, inherited identity terms were reorganized around ethnic belonging and colonial grievance. Democratic-era textbooks expanded the same vocabulary into contexts of reconciliation and sovereignty disputes, but this expansion remained overwhelmingly ethnic. In textbooks published after 2002, one quarter of sentences mentioning the *nation* (*minjok*) contain explicitly ethnic terms, while fewer than one percent contain civic or multiethnic language. The timing of change follows institutional reform rather than regime transition. The authoritarian reorganization accumulated across the first two curriculum cycles, and no detectable shift accompanies democratization in 1987. A first wave of change emerged under the Sixth Curriculum (1992–97), while the state still retained authorship, and a broader second wave followed the reopening of modern-history authorship in 2002. Regime change reaches the national narrative through the institutions that produce it.

Keywords: national identity, history textbooks, Korean history, natural language

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processing

1 Introduction

Political regimes are widely expected to shape the language a nation uses to teach about itself, and the school is where that teaching happens at scale (Alesina et al., 2021; Lott, 1999). Yet the empirical record is mixed. In some places democratization has reordered inherited national narratives and let new voices into the master story (Ho, 2022; Jo, 2025). Elsewhere it reworked them only slowly or shallowly, leaving the inherited narrative template in place under new authorship (Janmaat, 2007; Zajda, 2007), or it amplified the nationalism a prior regime had already built (Snyder, 2000). We argue that this variation has a structure. Regime type and the institutional arrangement governing the authorship and production of national narratives are conceptually linked but empirically separable. Regimes build the institutions that produce official narrative, and that origin ties the two together. Those institutions can also outlast a change of regime, or change while the regime holds. Where that happens, their imprint on the language of nationhood can be distinguished from the changes that follow regime change. Each leaves its own mark. Regime type shows in the character and content of identity language. The production arrangement paces when and how much it changes. That language is our focus here. We ask how it differs across regime types, and when it changes relative to regime transitions and to reforms of the institution that authors the narrative.

We take up the question in South Korea, whose national history textbooks reach back more than a century and pass through several distinct arrangements for who is authorized to write them. The regime and the textbook institution change on different schedules. Colonial authorities controlled the curriculum until 1945. The postwar republic certified textbooks supplied by competing publishers. A 1973 reform replaced certification with a single state-authored textbook, issued from 1974, and a 2002 reform returned modern history authorship to competing publishers. Apart from the 1945 break, which changed regime and arrangement together, none of these institutional changes coincides with a change of regime. That staggering lets us hold regime type and authorship arrangement apart and measure

how each is reflected in the language of national identity.

National history is an unusually hard test of the relationship. It is the school subject most resistant to revision. Where social studies and ethics took up multiculturalism and globalization in the democratic era (R. J. Moon & Koo, 2011; Watson, 2010), *kuksa* remained the curricular home of the master narrative (H. Kim & Kim, 2019; Shin, 2006), the discourse a state with a new vision has the strongest reason to rewrite and the least latitude to. The state monopoly over textbook production makes the test even more stringent. From 1974 to 2002 a single government body, the National Institute of Korean History (NIKH), wrote the one official textbook used in every classroom, so its volumes read as direct state speech rather than an aggregate of independent scholarship (H. Kim & Kim, 2019). If the language of nationhood changes even here, and those changes arrive on the production institution’s schedule, the relationship we describe is likely to be real and meaningful.

Using large language models (LLMs), we identify the relevant identity terms from the corpus itself and track how each is used with sentence-level embeddings across the full sequence. We then read the institutional changes one at a time. Liberation rewrites the vocabulary of nationhood outright. The modern lexicon of the nation enters the textbooks, and the colonial frame falls away. Under postwar certification that vocabulary settles into a shared, established baseline. The 1973 monopoly reorganizes the meanings of the inherited terms, widening the ones useful for legitimation and holding others in place. The 1987 democratic transition, which left the monopoly untouched, registers no detectable change at all. The new regime first appears in the language at the 6th Curriculum of 1992–97, while the state still wrote the single textbook, so democratization shows in the language before authorship pluralizes. The 2002 return to competing publishers brings a second and broader wave. Both waves widen the inherited ethnonational frame, which stays in place.

The paper makes three contributions. Substantively, we show that regime type and the production institution are separately visible in the language of national identity. Regime change reaches the national narrative through the authorship institution it eventually re-

shapes, and on that institution’s slower clock. Detectable change therefore lags the regime transition. The framing extends Jo (2025) on storytelling elites and connects to institutionalist accounts of layered change (Mahoney & Thelen, 2010) and path-dependent timing (Pierson, 2004). Empirically, we analyze all sixty-seven textbooks together. To our knowledge, this is the first full-corpus computational analysis of Korean national history textbooks in the English-language literature. Methodologically, we offer a replicable pipeline for corpus-driven concept discovery using LLMs, benchmarked against BERTopic and Latent Dirichlet Allocation and paired with sentence embeddings for tracing change over time.

2 National Identity, Education, and Institutions

Nations, boundaries, and the role of education

Nations are imagined communities sustained by print culture and shared narrative (Anderson, 1983), resting on shared institutions and public culture (Smith, 1991, p. 14). National identity depends on symbolic boundaries that mark who counts as part of “we” (Wimmer, 2013). Those boundaries are political. They shift with institutions and power relations, and with whichever coalition controls narrative production (Brubaker, 1996; Wimmer, 2018).

Mass schooling is among the most powerful mechanisms of nation-building because it draws and reproduces social boundaries. Gellner and Hobsbawm regarded standardized education as central to modern nationalism because it scales a shared culture to the national level (Gellner, 1983; Hobsbawm, 1990). Weber’s study of nineteenth-century France provided compelling historical evidence for this argument, showing how schools were among the principal institutions through which peasants were transformed into French nationals (Weber, 1976).

This institutional linkage matters because school systems often predate the regimes that later inherit them. Across 109 countries over two centuries, state-controlled primary education generally emerged before democratization. In roughly three-quarters of countries

that eventually democratized, a majority of the population already had access to primary schooling before the transition (Paglayan, 2021). Political elites have also expanded public education in the aftermath of internal conflict to cultivate obedience and respect for authority (Paglayan, 2022).

The effects of these early educational experiences can endure long after the regimes that created them disappear. Orientations formed under the first mass-schooling regime often persist through subsequent political transitions (Darden & Grzymala-Busse, 2006). Ethnic narratives and historical memories may prove especially durable because they are embedded in cultural repertoires and symbolic artifacts that survive institutional turnover (Connor, 1994; Hutchinson, 2005). Direct evidence supports this claim. Voigtländer and Voth (2015), for example, show that anti-Semitic attitudes persisted among cohorts exposed to Nazi-era schooling despite decades of postwar democratic education.

Textbooks distill these processes into standardized form and provide one of the most portable expressions of what states want children to learn. Children develop durable orientations toward authority and nationhood early in life (Jennings & Niemi, 1974). Textbooks preserve what Apple (1993) calls “official knowledge”: the understanding of the past and the polity that states authorize for transmission in democracies and autocracies alike. This is why comparative scholars treat textbooks as a privileged record of state-sanctioned narratives that can be analyzed systematically across countries and over time (Meyer et al., 2010; Pingel, 2010; Soysal & Wong, 2007).

Nor does this nationalizing function disappear as curricula become more globalized. A comparative analysis of 576 secondary social science textbooks from 78 countries found that nationalist narratives remained just as prevalent, on average, in more globalized settings (Lerch et al., 2017). What textbooks contain reflects not the preferences of a small group of scholars, but what states choose to transmit to virtually every child.

This role may be even more consequential under authoritarianism, where schools reach citizens through standardized instruction over long periods of time (Wedeen, 1999). Cross-

national evidence suggests that educational indoctrination is associated with weaker pro-democratic attitudes and stronger forms of regime-compatible political mobilization (Tetteh & Edgell, 2026). Likewise, Cantoni et al. (2017) show that curriculum reform in China reshaped students' political attitudes in the direction encouraged by the revised textbooks. Authoritarian and democratic systems thus share the task of nation-building, even as they differ in the institutional arrangements through which they pursue it.

Regime type, institutions, and the grand narrative

Comparative work on national narratives usually treats regime type as the primary driver of change. Authoritarian and democratic states produce different master narratives (Dierkes, 2010; Wertsch, 2002), and transitions between them mark where the language of nationhood shifts, however slowly and contentiously the schoolbooks follow (Aguilar, 2002; Cole, 2007). Historical-institutionalist scholarship complicates this account by introducing institutional time. Identity-political equilibria are stable except at critical junctures (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007). Most institutional change is layered, with a stable substrate persisting while new elements assemble around it (Mahoney & Thelen, 2010; Thelen, 2004). Path-dependent processes generate lags, so the discursive consequences of reform arrive well after formal change (Beissinger, 2002; Pierson, 2004). Much of this literature, however, treats regime and narrative-producing institutions as moving together. When the regime changes, the textbook institutions are assumed to change with it.

We separate the two. The institutional arrangement that produces national narrative, who is authorized to write official history and under what rules, is itself created by political regimes, which is what links the two. Yet it need not move in lockstep with the regime that established it. An arrangement can outlast the government that created it, or it can be reformed while that government remains in power. In such cases, political institutions and narrative-producing institutions come apart. Each leaves a distinct imprint: the regime shows in the content of the narrative, while the production arrangement sets its timing.

Because the institutional reforms eventually set in motion by regime change can lag that transition by years, visible shifts in national narrative may arrive long after the regime transition itself. On this account, regime type reaches the narrative through the authorship institution and according to the institution's slower clock. A change of regime and a change in the textbook therefore need not occur together.

Jo (2025) offers the closest version of this argument. Jo treats democratization as a critical juncture because it expands the set of "storytelling elites" authorized to define the nation, with the direction of any reordering depending on which elites prevail. Developed comparatively across South Korea and Taiwan, this framework can be extended into a more general account of institutional arrangement. We treat the number of authors a system authorizes as one key parameter of that arrangement. Opening authorship to competing voices pluralizes the discourse. Collapsing authorship into a single authority centralizes it.

Other arguments about regime type fit within this framework rather than competing with it. Incomplete democratization can intensify nationalist appeals because political elites mobilize through identity (Snyder, 2000), while state strategies of nation-building track geopolitical alignments as well as domestic institutions (Mylonas, 2012). In each case, the regime operates through the arrangement that authors the narrative, and textbook language carries the imprint of both.

Whether institutional change reshapes identity discourse is one question. The direction that change takes is another. Laitin (1998) argues that identity choices are structured by the alternatives that institutional settings make politically viable, while Posner (2004) generalizes this logic by showing that mobilizing along a particular identity dimension depends on whether doing so can generate a winning coalition under the prevailing rules. On this reading, the production arrangement governs when the narrative can change. The regime and the alternative identities it renders politically viable govern the direction of that change.

Where a politically viable alternative is institutionally available, opening the arrangement provides a new authorial coalition with material to redirect the narrative. Where no such

alternative exists, opening the arrangement widens the inherited frame instead. Comparative evidence points to both outcomes. In Taiwan, democratization coincided with a curricular opening that allowed a civic-territorial identity to displace the “One China” frame (Chen et al., 2023; Ho, 2022). In post-Pinochet Chile, plural framings of the authoritarian past entered the curriculum (Oteíza & Castro, 2019). Putin-era Russia moved in the opposite direction, centralizing history education around a single state textbook as political institutions closed (Feklyunina et al., 2025). Japan illustrates the same institutional channel operating within a consolidated democracy, where decades of textbook conflict have unfolded through the Ministry of Education’s certification system (*kentei*) rather than through regime change itself (Hein & Selden, 2000; Nozaki, 2008; Nozaki & Selden, 2009).

In the Korean case, the arrangement operates at two levels. The authorship-system level governs who is authorized to write the textbook. Three reforms restructured this level across our corpus: the 1945 postcolonial transfer from Japanese imperial rule, the 1973 consolidation into a single state-authored textbook system (*kukchǒngje*) that concentrated authorship in NIKH, and the 2002 return to a certified system of competing publishers (*kǒmjǒngje*) for modern and contemporary history. The curriculum-cycle level governs the syllabus and content directives within which a textbook is produced. Each national curriculum revision (1st–7th, plus the 7th Revised) constitutes a within-system event that may have its own discursive consequences even when the authorship system remains unchanged. The 1992 Sixth Curriculum provides the clearest example: NIKH remained the sole author, but its remit was rewritten under a democratic government.

Each of these moments constitutes a candidate critical juncture (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007). The framework therefore yields a falsifiable expectation rather than a post hoc description. We expect discursive reorganization at moments of authorship-system change (1945, 1973, and 2002) and, in particular, no comparable reorganization at the 1987 regime transition, which left *kukchǒngje* intact. Focusing on *kuksa* concentrates the test on the

school subject least open to revision (Ahn, 2012; R. J. Moon & Koo, 2011).¹

Korean history education and the politics of *kuksa*

Korea’s modern textbook tradition dates to the Kabo reforms of 1894–95 (Seth, 2010; Wells, 1990). Under Japanese colonial rule Korean history was subordinated to imperial priorities and rewritten (Caprio, 2009; Pai, 2000). Nationalism survived through intellectual and cultural work rather than mass schooling, as writers such as Sin Ch’aeho developed the *nation* as a modern historical subject circulating among educated publics rather than through a sovereign school system (Em, 1999, 2013; Robinson, 1988; Schmid, 2002).

After 1945, history education became a mass nation-building project that taught the republic through anti-colonial memory and anti-communist patriotism (S. Moon, 2005; Seth, 2002; Sorensen, 1994). The 1973–74 shift to *kukchǒngje* intensified this mission (Guex, 2015). Once NIKH assumed direct authorship of the national textbook, the state could standardize the narrative down to the level of wording. The resulting texts promoted a ‘purified’ *nation* narrative and militant anti-communism while providing the regime with a legitimating account of the past that reframed the 1961 coup as a ‘revolution’ (H. Kim & Kim, 2019; Shin, 2006). This system remained in place through the 1990s and the Fifth Curriculum, long after the democratic transition had begun.

Democratization loosened the state’s monopoly without rendering *kuksa* politically neutral. In 2002, modern and contemporary Korean history returned to the authorization system, creating space for privately produced textbooks that offered more varied narratives (Seth, 2010). The period from 1987 to 2002 is analytically revealing. The political institutions defining the regime had changed, but the curricular institution responsible for producing the textbook had not. It represents a case of layered institutional change, in which

¹On embedding-based measurement of conceptual change, see Rodriguez et al. (2023) and Gentzkow et al. (2019). The BERTopic and LDA benchmarks, together with the contrastive-variance procedure, address these concerns, as do the leave-one-book-out and cluster-bootstrap robustness checks. We do not claim that any single measure exhausts a concept’s meaning. Rather, we argue that the cross-regime differences reported here are robust to the measurement choices that the literature identifies as most likely to affect the results.

a stable substrate persists across a regime boundary (Mahoney & Thelen, 2010). Yet national history remained a high-stakes domain. Beginning after 2003, a New Right campaign sought to recenter the narrative around the 1948 founding of the republic and displace the *nation*-centered account (Vierthaler, 2021; Yang, 2021). Its culmination was the 2015 attempt to restore a single state-authored textbook, an effort that provoked broad opposition and ultimately collapsed with the Park Geun-hye administration (H. Kim & Kim, 2019). Throughout these shifts, *kuksa* remained the place where the nation narrated itself in its most formal voice.

Comparative research reinforces this point. North and South Korea have produced rival versions of “Koreanness” within a shared ethnic frame. Each casts the other as the national foil in its school textbooks, with one narrative tied to democratic legitimacy and global integration, and the other to revolutionary struggle (Hart, 1999; Jager, 2003; Won & Huntington, 2021). Shin et al. (1999) describes this as the paradox of divided Korea: shared ethnicity sustains a common language of nationhood even as each state continually reworks its meaning. More broadly, states organize the past around preferred narratives of pride and grievance (Lin et al., 2009; Ryu & Kim, 2022). Similar patterns appear across textbook systems throughout the wider region (Shin & Sneider, 2011), while identity-conformity pressures appear stronger in South Korea, consistent with the long reach of uniform state narratives (Denney et al., 2026).

Most scholarship on Korean textbooks relies on close readings of selected volumes or comparisons of curriculum frameworks (Lee, 2024; Ryu & Kim, 2022; Won & Huntington, 2021). Computational analyses have only recently begun to engage with the corpus as a whole (Chen et al., 2023; Lucy et al., 2020). We instead analyze all sixty-seven textbooks together. This is where the paper’s leverage lies. Because *kuksa* is the part of the curriculum designed to resist change, change within it is especially informative about the relationship between political institutions and national narrative. We do not test this claim against more flexible subjects such as social studies (*sahoe*), ethics, or geography. That comparison

remains an important task for future research.

3 Data

Rationale and scope

We study state-directed national identity through a corpus of officially issued Korean history textbooks. Most of the collection comes from the National Institute of Korean History (NIKH, *Kuksa P'yŏnch'an Wiwŏnhoe*) digital archive, particularly the *Yŏktae Kuksa Kyogwasŏ* collection, which spans the late nineteenth century through the early 2000s. NIKH has not yet digitized the later democratic-era publications. For those volumes, we rely on scanned PDFs from the Georg Eckert Institute (GEI).

The GEI textbooks were processed using DeepSeek-OCR, a 3-billion-parameter document vision-language model (Wei et al., 2025). We then cleaned the resulting text of residual HTML, repeated characters, and decorative symbols, reducing character-level noise by 23.3

The merged corpus comprises 67 textbooks, including 51 from NIKH and 16 from GEI (Table 1). It spans the Kabo reforms and Korean Empire, the colonial period, the U.S. military government and early republic, the state-authored era, and the democratic transition through 2016. This temporal breadth allows us to separate two questions that are often conflated. The first concerns historical rupture, above all the transition from colonial rule to post-liberation statehood. The second concerns variation within the post-liberation tradition itself, as textbook production moved through postwar, authoritarian, and democratic institutional settings.

Subject coverage follows NIKH’s own curation rather than a post hoc filtering decision. The archive groups *kuksa* with other state-issued historical materials. These include elementary social studies (*sahoe*) textbooks containing substantial historical content, the modern and contemporary Korean history (*Han’guk kŭnhyŏndaesa*) volumes taught alongside *kuksa* under the 7th National Curriculum, and one 3rd-curriculum world history textbook pub-

lished in 1973. Taking NIKH’s judgment as the inclusion criterion avoids substituting our own categorization for that of the institution under study.

Han’guk kŭnhyŏndaesa warrants particular attention. Beginning in 2002, it was taught as a separate modern history volume alongside *kuksa*, and NIKH classifies it within the *Yŏktae Kuksa Kyogwasŏ* collection. Including these texts therefore follows NIKH’s curation while preserving the genre in which the post-2002 *kŏmjŏngje* reform most directly reorganized authorship. The second wave visible in the corpus thus reflects both the shift to *kŏmjŏngje* and the addition of this curricular component. For this reason, the sub-era analysis in Appendix H.2 reports the trajectories of the 6th Curriculum (promulgated in 1992, with NIKH volumes published from 1995 to 2001) and the 7th Curriculum and later (*kŏmjŏngje*, 2002–) separately.

Corpus structure

The analysis file stores one row per textbook, identified by a stable identifier (`book_id`) and accompanied by bibliographic metadata and two text fields. The first, `full_text`, contains the continuous prose and serves as the input to the term-discovery and sentence-embedding pipelines. The second, `processed_text`, is a noun-focused derivative used for frequency analysis. Metadata normalize recurring volume markers such as *kwŏn* and *sang/ha*, and all text is encoded in NFC Unicode.

For count-based analyses, we preprocess the text using KiwiPiePy by retaining common and proper nouns (NNG/NNP), merging compound nouns, and removing single-syllable non-proper nouns. This step reflects a practical feature of Korean morphology: inflection produces many surface forms for the same underlying concept. Because preprocessing choices can shape the results of unsupervised analyses (Denny & Spirling, 2018), we restrict this noun-filtering procedure to frequency counts alone. The term-discovery and embedding pipelines instead operate directly on `full_text`.

For descriptive analyses, we collapse the corpus into five historically grounded periods:

Late Chosŏn, Colonial, Postwar, Authoritarian, and Democratic. The frequency analysis uses all five periods.

For the semantic-axis analysis, however, we narrow our focus to the two post-liberation transitions. A full-timeline analysis (Appendix F) showed that the Colonial-to-Postwar transition had a mean absolute logistic shift of 1.64, roughly four times larger than either of the post-liberation transitions. This difference marks a boundary between discourse systems rather than variation within a shared one. Late Chosŏn dynastic historiography and colonial-era Japanese imperial narratives belonged to a fundamentally different pedagogical project from post-liberation textbooks organized around the independence movement and the division of the peninsula. We therefore treat this rupture as the historical precondition for the later dynamics we study, rather than as a comparable instance of those dynamics.

Period	Years	Representative titles	School levels	N
Late Chosŏn	1895–1910	<i>Chosŏn yŏksa</i> (조선역사); <i>Chosŏn yŏktae saryak</i> (조선역대사략); <i>Tongguk yŏksa</i> / <i>Tongguk saryak</i> series	Elem / MS / HS	14
Colonial	1910–1945	<i>Simsang sohakkyo kuksa poch'ung</i> series (심상소학교 국사보충); teacher and pupil supplements issued under colonial authority	Elem / Supp.	4
Postwar	1945–1972	<i>Kuksa kyobon</i> (국사교본); 1st- and 2nd-curriculum middle and high school <i>kuksa</i> ; elementary social studies volumes with national history content	Elem / MS / HS	8
Authoritarian	1973–1993	3rd-, 4th-, and 5th-curriculum <i>kuksa</i> textbooks; <i>National Education Charter</i> era texts; state-authored elementary, middle, and high school volumes	Elem / MS / HS	19
Democratic	1993–2016	6th- and 7th-curriculum <i>kuksa</i> ; privately published <i>Han'guk kŭnhyŏndaesa</i> (한국근현대사); revised <i>Han'guksa</i> (한국사)	Elem / MS / HS	22
Total	1895– 2016			67

Table 1: Coverage of the textbook corpus by period.

Note: Period labels follow the regime-oriented periodization used in the main text. Representative titles are illustrative rather than exhaustive. The merged corpus contains 51 NIKH textbooks and 16 GEI textbooks processed via OCR.

Institutional context

The corpus was produced under authorship arrangements that do not line up with the regime transitions. From 1945 to 1974, South Korea used an authorization system (*kŏmjŏngje*) in which private publishers produced textbooks subject to state approval. In 1973 the Park Chung Hee government replaced it with a state-monopoly authorship system (*kukchŏngje*). NIKH became the direct author of the national history textbook. The first state-authored volumes were issued in 1974, and our Authoritarian period begins with the 1973 announcement of the reform (H. Kim & Kim, 2019). The arrangement outlived Park, continued under Chun Doo Hwan, and survived the democratic transition of 1987. Modern and contemporary Korean history returned to *kŏmjŏngje* only in 2002, when privately produced *Han’guk kŭnhyŏndaesa* textbooks began to appear (H. Kim & Kim, 2019; Seth, 2010).

This fifteen-year gap between political democratization (1987) and textbook pluralization (2002) is analytically central to our argument. *Kukchŏngje* textbooks are best understood as direct state speech rather than as an aggregation of independent scholarly judgments. Even after democratization, textbooks remained NIKH-authored until 2002. Only the post-2002 volumes were produced by independent author teams. Resolving this institutional structure at the curriculum level, rather than collapsing everything into a single Democratic period, allows us to identify where and when discursive change actually occurs.

4 Methods

The analysis proceeds in four stages. We begin with cross-model term discovery using the full 67-textbook corpus. We then examine per-period frequency patterns, followed by sentence-level embedding and, finally, the estimation of semantic axes for each regime transition. Figure 1 at the end of this section summarizes the complete analytical pipeline.

Term discovery

Deciding which concepts to track is a central challenge in the study of national identity. Rather than beginning with a hand-constructed keyword list, we adopt a corpus-driven discovery procedure based on large language models (LLMs). The process unfolds in three steps: extraction, validation, and scoring. Cross-model consensus determines the final set of terms.

For extraction, we used four 32B-class models drawn from distinct training traditions: EXAONE-Deep (LG AI Research, Korea), Aya Expanse (Cohere, Canada), Qwen2.5 (Alibaba, China), and Gemma 3 (Google, United States) (LG AI Research, 2025). Each model received the same Korean zero-shot prompt, which asked it to identify nouns and noun phrases related to national identity across seven thematic domains using 4,000-character `full_text` windows (Appendix D).² Raw outputs were then reduced to root nouns using KiwiPiePy.

Validation proceeded in two stages. Candidate terms first had to pass a per-window cosine-similarity check using `paraphrase-multilingual-MiniLM-L12-v2` and meet a corpus-match threshold of at least three occurrences. The surviving candidates were then ranked by a weighted score composed of frequency (40%) and semantic similarity (60%), and terms scoring above a fixed per-model weighted-frequency floor ($wf \geq 50$) were treated as that model’s selections (Appendix D). A term entered the final set if at least three of the four models selected it and if it represented a conceptual category rather than a proper noun.

We excluded specific historical entities, including dynasties, kingdoms, and the country itself, because they do not possess an axis of contested meaning. Nine identity terms remained: *nation* (*minjok*, 민족; ethnos), *state* (*kukka*, 국가), *citizen* (*kungmin*, 국민), *independence* (*tongnip*, 독립), *democracy* (*minjujuui*, 민주주의), *unification* (*t’ongil*, 통일), *liberation* (*haebang*, 해방), *history* (*yŏksa*, 역사), and *territory* (*yŏngt’o*, 영토). We use the italicized

²Smaller EXAONE models (2.4B and 7.8B) were also tested. All three sizes achieve perfect recall on the final term set, while precision improves at larger scale (Appendix A).

English terms throughout the paper. The complete glossary appears in SI Appendix A.1.

We validated this list against BERTopic and Latent Dirichlet Allocation. BERTopic identified all nine terms, Latent Dirichlet Allocation five (Appendix A). The final list reproduces from the corpus by independent methods, even though no single conventional model produces the same set on its own.

For each textbook we count occurrences of the nine target terms in `processed_text`, normalize per 1,000 tokens, and aggregate by period (school-level breakdown in Appendix E).

Sentence-level analysis

Frequency tells us which terms rise or fall. It does not tell us whether a term appears in a wider or narrower range of contexts, or in a different one altogether. We split `full_text` into sentences with Kiwi and keep every sentence containing one of the nine target terms, embedding each with `BM-K/KoSimCSE-roberta-multitask` (B.-M. Kim, 2021), a 768-dimensional Korean RoBERTa encoder (mean-pooling, `max_seq_length` 512). Before any axes are fit, embeddings from all nine terms are pooled and standardized to zero mean and unit variance per dimension. Pooling lets each axis be fit once per transition on a shared coordinate system, so per-term shifts are projections of (term, period) centroids onto a common direction and are comparable across terms. Standardization keeps a few high-variance dimensions from dominating and puts shift values in one unit, where 1.0 is one standard deviation of the pooled embeddings along the axis. The approach builds on diachronic-embedding work on semantic change (Hamilton et al., 2016; Kozlowski et al., 2019; Rodman, 2020) and the broader text-as-data program (Gentzkow et al., 2019; Grimmer & Stewart, 2013).

The encoder was trained on contemporary Korean and has not been independently validated on pre-1980s texts or hanja-mixed orthography. Two features of the design help bound this risk. First, the axes are estimated separately for each transition using pooled within-transition sentences rather than being compared across embedding spaces. Second, leave-one-book-out jackknife analyses show that the LR and cPCA axes remain stable un-

der resampling, with median displacements of 4–6° (Appendix H.4), the opposite of what we would expect if the axes were being driven by the orthographic peculiarities of a single period. Notably, the largest orthographic discontinuity, the Colonial-to-Postwar transition, also shows the largest semantic shift. For this reason, we restrict the semantic-axis analysis to the more homogeneous post-liberation corpus.

For each adjacent-period transition, we define three complementary axes, each designed to capture a different aspect of discursive change. The discriminative axis asks how readily the two periods can be distinguished from one another. The contrastive-variance axis asks where the later period exhibits greater diversity of contexts than the earlier one. The alignment-residual axis asks what differences remain after the two periods’ embedding spaces have been rotated into the closest possible alignment.

We operationalize these axes as follows, with full specifications and formulas reported in Appendix H. The discriminative (LR) axis is defined as the unit-normalized coefficient vector of an L2-regularized logistic regression ($C=1.0$, balanced classes) fit to predict period membership from pooled sentences. Per-term shifts are then measured by projecting the centroids of the two periods onto this axis.

Following Abid et al. (2018), the contrastive-variance (cPCA) axis is defined as the leading eigenvector of $\Sigma_{\text{later}} - \alpha \Sigma_{\text{earlier}}$, where $\alpha = \text{tr}(\Sigma_{\text{later}})/\text{tr}(\Sigma_{\text{earlier}})$, with the sign pinned to the later-period centroid. This axis supports two distinct measurements: a per-term centroid shift and a per-term standard deviation ratio of sentence projections that indexes contextual widening. Because cPCA selects directions of variance growth by construction, these standard deviation ratios are biased upward relative to 1. We therefore also compute direction-free measures of spread, including the trace ratio, reverse-cPCA, and participation ratio, to identify cases of genuine compression (Appendix H.6).

Adapting the approach of Hamilton et al. (2016), the alignment-residual (PA) axis is defined as the leading right-singular vector of the residual matrix obtained after Procrustes alignment of the two periods. Under leave-one-book-out resampling, this axis appears to

be dominated by sample noise, exhibiting a median displacement of 86° compared with 6° for the LR and cPCA axes (Appendix H.4). We therefore do not interpret it at the level of individual terms.

Ethnic and civic marker counts

For the question of whether democratic-era widening of *nation* reframes or amplifies the inherited ethnonational vocabulary, we additionally report the proportion of post-2002 *nation* sentences containing an explicit ethnic-community marker (drawn from a fixed list of four terms, *our nation* [uri minjok], *the Korean people* [hanminjok], *compatriots* [tongp'o], and *unitary nation* [tanil minjok]) versus a civic or multiethnic marker (*multiethnic* [tam-injok], *multicultural* [tamunhwa], *citizenship* [siminkwŏn], *migrants* [ijumin], and *foreigners* [oegugin]). The counts rest on exact substring match in sentence text and are a conservative lower bound on each category, since rarer or more euphemistic constructions are not captured. Our findings on contextual range come from the sentence-embedding measures above. The fixed-list counts are reported only as a transparency check on the direction of the contextual shift. To confirm that the asymmetry is not an artifact of restricting the denominator to *nation* sentences, we recomputed the same marker rates across all nine identity-term sentences from 2002 onward. The imbalance persists. Explicit ethnic-community markers appear in roughly 11% of post-2002 identity-term sentences, against under 1% carrying civic or multiethnic markers. For *territory* we report one further count of the same kind, the share of post-2002 *territory* sentences that contain 독도 (Dokdo), again an exact substring match on sentence text.

Robustness checks

With only 67 textbooks, any single volume that uses the target terms in unusual ways has the potential to influence the fitted axes. We therefore evaluate the robustness of our findings using two book-level resampling procedures (Efron & Tibshirani, 1993). The first is

a leave-one-book-out (LOBO) jackknife, which drops one textbook at a time, refits all three axes, and measures the resulting angular displacement relative to the full-data solution. The PA-axis instability reported above is the LOBO result for that axis. The second is a cluster bootstrap, which resamples entire textbooks with replacement, preserves within-book correlation, and refits the cPCA axis on each resample ($B = 500$ per transition, seed 2026). We report medians, 95

We apply the cluster bootstrap only to cPCA. The LR axis already has per-term cross-validated accuracy estimates, and all eighteen LR shifts point in the same direction. The PA axis, by contrast, is dominated by noise. cPCA is therefore the only axis for which per-term signs are both substantively meaningful and not obvious in advance.

Full procedural details and book-level results appear in Appendices H.4 and H.7. This is an observational corpus study and was not pre-registered. In place of design-side pre-commitment, the three robustness procedures, cross-model term-discovery consensus, the LOBO jackknife, and the cPCA cluster bootstrap, serve to constrain analyst degrees of freedom.

Beyond these procedures, we conducted the checks that a critical reader would be most likely to request. Scripts and outputs are included in the replication package. A placebo exercise refitting cPCA on random within-Authoritarian splits, with authorship held fixed, yields mean absolute per-term shifts of approximately 1.2, comparable in magnitude to the institutional transitions. cPCA *magnitude* is therefore partly mechanical. We consequently interpret sign concordance, the largest shifts, and the timing shown in Figure 5 more heavily than aggregate magnitude.

On the discriminative axis, pooled-sentence five-fold cross-validation accuracy separates the institutional transitions at 0.72–0.75, whereas the 1987 boundary within *kukchöngje* separates only at 0.65, only slightly above an arbitrary within-period split (0.60). A *kuksa*-only sensitivity analysis that excludes the six *Han’guk künhyöndaesa* volumes reduces the largest post-2002 shifts, with *unification* shrinking from approximately +2.5 to +0.5. Even

so, seven of the nine terms continue to move in the same direction as the pooled democratic transition. We therefore attribute the magnitude of the second wave jointly to the *kŏmjŏngje* reform and to the inclusion of the contemporary history genre.

Additional checks point in the same direction. Removing all hanja characters before re-embedding reproduces all nine per-term cPCA signs across both transitions. The cleaned GEI OCR contains no more residual non-content characters (approximately 1.1%) than the natively digital NIKH texts (approximately 1.0%). Finally, book-weighted centroids correlate strongly with the sentence-weighted shifts ($r = 0.77$).

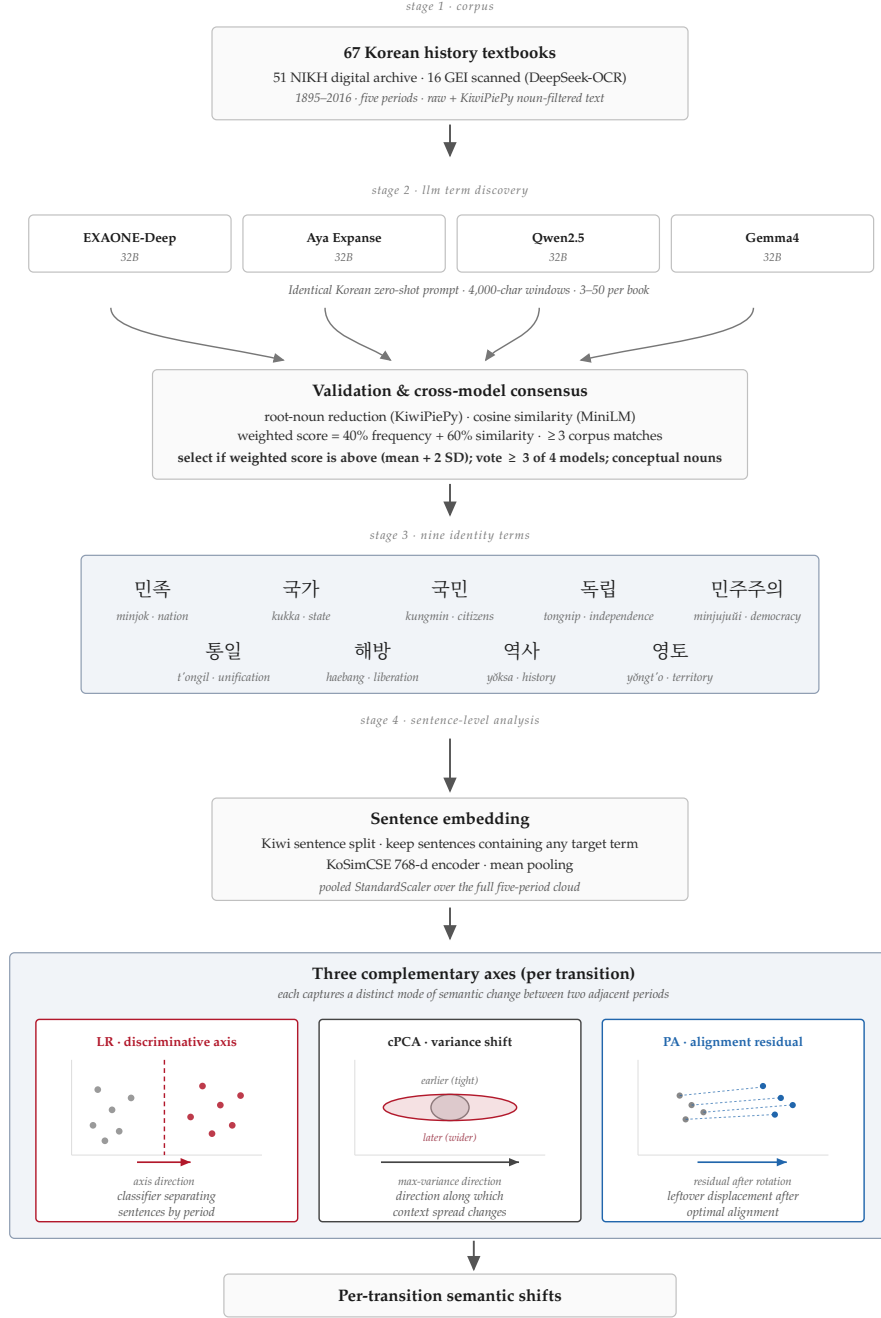


Figure 1: Analysis pipeline.

Note: Four 32B-class language models from distinct training traditions propose candidate identity terms from the 67-textbook corpus; cross-model voting and corpus validation yield the final set of nine. Each term then anchors a sentence-level analysis with three axes fit per transition: discriminative (LR), contrastive variance (cPCA), and alignment residual (PA). Insets indicate what each axis measures.

5 Results

The vocabulary of nationhood

Before turning to semantic change we want to know when the vocabulary of modern Korean nationhood entered the textbook corpus at all. Figure 2 reports mean frequency per 1,000 tokens for the nine identity terms across the five historical periods. The rupture at liberation is the dominant feature. Most terms that later anchor postcolonial identity discourse barely register in Late Chosŏn and Colonial textbooks. *Nation* appears only rarely before 1945 and never in Colonial books, as with *citizens*, while *democracy* does not appear at all and *liberation* registers in only a handful of Late Chosŏn sentences. Korean nationhood, as a textbook vocabulary, had not yet cohered.

After 1945 the vocabulary settles into public education. With liberation and the founding of the Republic, *nation*, *state*, *citizens*, *independence*, and *history* all turn up at substantial frequencies. *Democracy* enters the corpus for the first time. Two pre-liberation terms run against the pattern. *Territory* peaks in the Colonial period under Japanese imperial historiography,³ while *unification* shows up in reference to historical consolidation (above all Unified Silla) rather than the modern problem of national division. Both persist after liberation with substantially altered semantic roles.

These nine terms then run across Postwar, Authoritarian, and Democratic periods with shifting balance. *Nation* and *state* peak under authoritarianism, *democracy* in the early postwar era. But frequency measures volume, not meaning or range, and not position, for which we need sentence-level analysis.

³In the 1940 *Simsang sohakkyo kuksa poch'ung* (심상소학교 국사보충), for instance, the *Mimana Nihonfu* hypothesis (任那日本府説) is taught as fact, with Empress Jingū “ruling the territories of the Three Han” after conquering Silla (ta_p31r). The companion teacher’s manual partitions the peninsula between Chinese northern dominion and Japanese southern influence (ta_p41r).

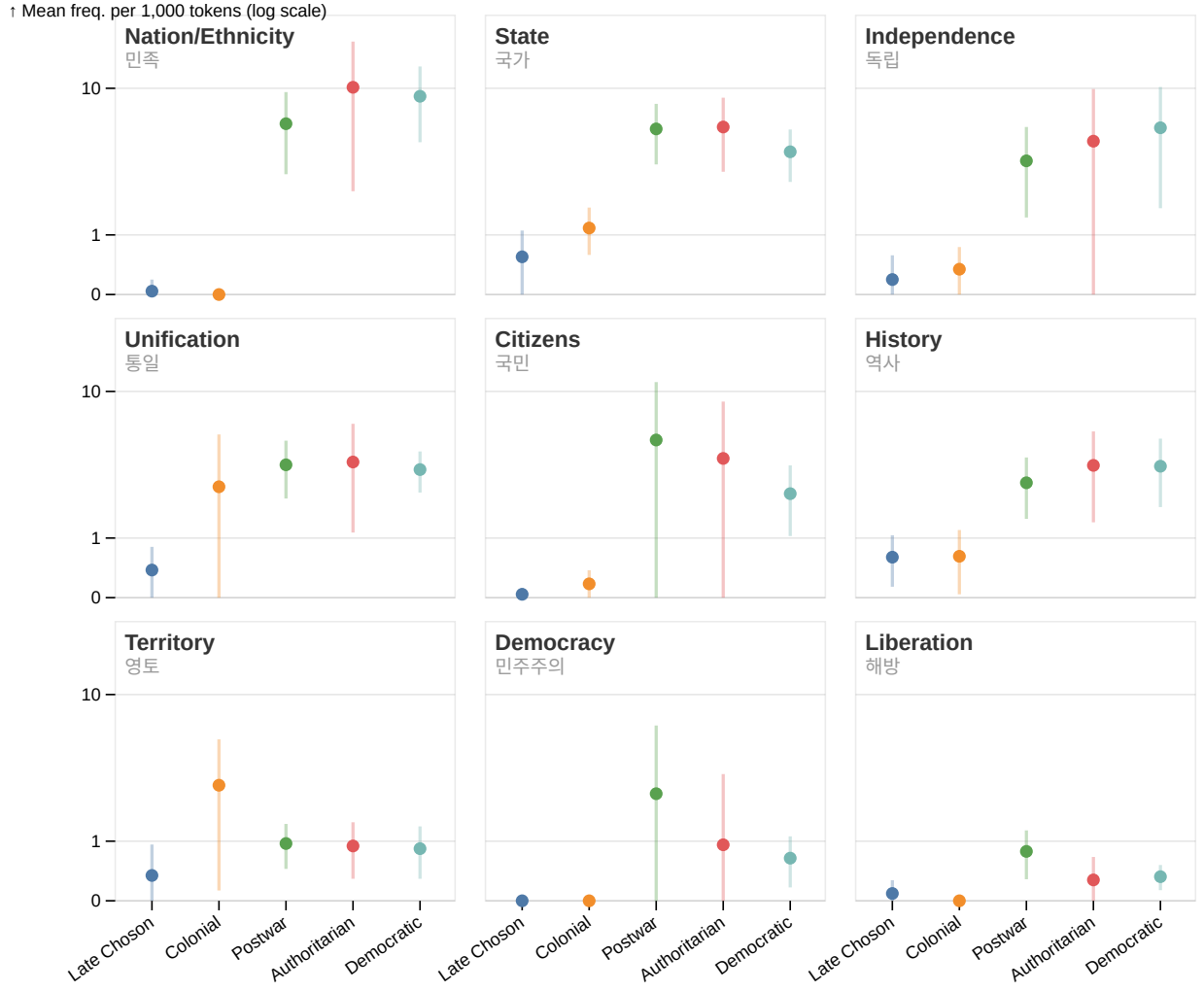


Figure 2: Frequency of the nine identity terms by period.

Note: Mean frequency per 1,000 tokens in each of the five historical periods. The y-axis is symmetric-log (linear below 1) so absent and rare pre-liberation terms stay visible alongside much higher post-liberation usage; tick labels read in raw frequencies. Error bars are one standard deviation across textbooks within a period.

Three axes of semantic change

We focus on the two post-liberation transitions, Postwar-to-Authoritarian and Authoritarian-to-Democratic, where the institutional and pedagogical project runs continuously. The Colonial-to-Postwar break belongs to a different discourse system. Most identity terms enter the corpus only at liberation, and a five-period run produces Colonial-to-Postwar logistic shifts roughly four times larger than either later transition, which would swamp the comparison (Appendix F). Following the national curriculum cycles, we group textbooks into three macro-periods: *Postwar* (1st–2nd curricula, 1945–1972, 8 textbooks), *Authoritarian* (3rd–5th, 1973–1993, 19 textbooks), and *Democratic* (6th–7th, 1993–2016, 22 textbooks). For each term and transition we report shifts on the three axes from the Methods (LR, cPCA, PA). Table 2 gives the full results. The macro-periods follow the regime periodization, so shifts across them measure regime-level differences.

Term	Postwar to Authoritarian			Authoritarian to Democratic		
	LR	cPCA	PA	LR	cPCA	PA
Independence	0.46	3.26	−0.96	0.38	0.13	0.31
Nation	0.45	2.05	−1.13	0.40	0.65	1.20
Citizens	0.44	2.17	−0.76	0.44	1.36	0.48
History	0.44	1.85	0.15	0.44	−1.45	1.63
Democracy	0.36	0.39	−1.38	0.49	0.73	0.80
Unification	0.38	0.28	−0.80	0.45	2.53	0.86
State	0.44	−0.69	0.35	0.32	0.57	0.61
Territory	0.47	0.03	−0.02	0.32	−0.71	1.02
Liberation	0.42	−1.64	1.12	0.42	−0.16	1.58
Mean	0.43	0.85	−0.38	0.40	0.41	0.94
Mean (absolute)	0.43	1.37	0.74	0.40	0.92	0.94

Table 2: Semantic shifts for the nine identity terms across the two post-liberation transitions.

Note: Each cell is $\text{score}(\text{later}) - \text{score}(\text{earlier})$ in standard deviation units of the pooled embeddings, on three axes: discriminative (LR), contrastive variance (cPCA), and alignment residual (PA). The cPCA axis is sign-pinned to the pooled later-period centroid, so positive values mark movement with the dominant later-period direction and negative values against it. Contextual widening is measured separately by the SD ratio (Appendix H.5). The PA column is sample-noise-dominated and not interpreted per term (Appendix H.4).

In the aggregate the two transitions look comparable in magnitude (Postwar-to-Authoritarian

absolute shifts average 0.85, Authoritarian-to-Democratic 0.75; per-axis means in the last rows of Table 2), but the similarity hides internal differences. The cPCA axis is where the interpretable differences appear. Mean absolute cPCA centroid shifts of 1.37 and 0.92 exceed the LR shifts of 0.43 and 0.40, the PA axis is sample-noise-dominated and not read per term (Appendix H.4), and the four largest individual shifts (*independence* +3.26, *unification* +2.53, *citizens* +2.17, *nation* +2.05) all fall on the cPCA axis. Semantic change here is mostly about widening or narrowing the range of contexts a term appears in, with core reference largely preserved.

A direct measure of context width, the SD ratio of sentence projections on the cPCA axis (Appendix H.5), points the same way. All nine terms widen across the post-1987 era under the combined 6th-curriculum and post-2002 *kŏmjŏngje* reforms (SD ratios 1.01–1.31). Under *kukchŏngje* monopoly authorship, seven of the nine widen, while *independence* and *liberation* hold roughly constant (SD ratios 0.99) despite substantial centroid movement.

On the discriminative axis the story is about direction rather than magnitude. Per-term logistic classifiers separate the two periods above chance in all eighteen cases (mean per-term five-fold CV accuracy 0.71 and 0.73).⁴ Every centroid moves toward the later period across all nine terms and both transitions, so all eighteen LR shifts come out positive. The axis is fit once per transition on pooled sentences, so any term’s centroid could in principle project either way, and independent per-term variation would scatter the signs. That every term tracks the same boundary is a regime-level finding in its own right. Adjacent regime periods differ in identity language for every term, before any institutional timing is resolved.

Our analytical interest sits with the cPCA axis. Figure 3 plots its per-term shifts. During Postwar-to-Authoritarian, six terms move with the pooled direction (*independence*, *citizens*, *nation*, *history*, *democracy*, *unification*), *territory* sits at zero (+0.03), and two move against it (*state*, *liberation*). During Authoritarian-to-Democratic, six move with the pooled direction

⁴Per-term, per-period sentence counts in the two analyzed transitions range from 73 (*liberation*, Postwar) to 5,764 (*nation*, Democratic). We read terms with fewer than 100 Postwar sentences (*liberation*, *territory*) cautiously.

and three against it (*history*, *territory*, and, marginally, *liberation*). A book-level cluster bootstrap ($B = 500$) keeps this broad cluster structure across essentially every iteration. Sign concordance is high for the largest shifts and near chance for the smallest, so we read the cluster structure and the largest shifts as stable and treat smaller per-term signs as descriptive (Appendix H.7). The two regime eras differ in kind, selective appropriation under the authoritarian monopoly and broad-but-bounded expansion under democratization. The next two subsections develop the contrast.

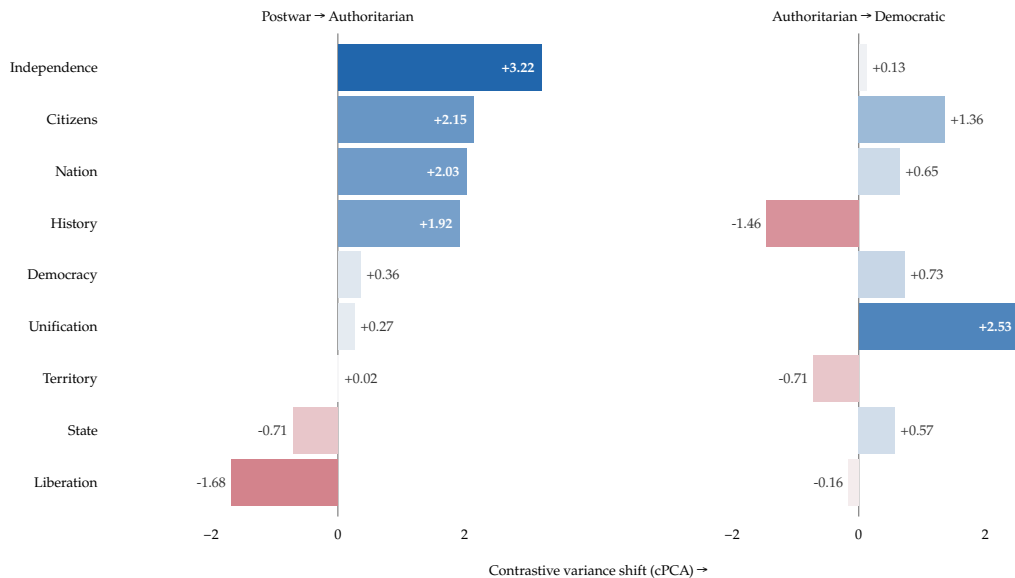


Figure 3: Per-term cPCA shifts across the two post-liberation transitions.

Note: Bars show each term’s contrastive-variance (cPCA) centroid shift, Postwar-to-Authoritarian in the left panel and Authoritarian-to-Democratic in the right. Positive values mark movement with the pooled later-period direction. Terms are ordered by their signed Postwar-to-Authoritarian shift. Widening (SD ratios) and per-term sentence counts appear in Appendices H.5 and H.6.

Selective appropriation under authoritarianism

The Postwar-to-Authoritarian transition is uneven across terms. Six concepts move along the pooled cPCA direction: *independence* (+3.26), *citizens* (+2.17), *nation* (+2.05), *history* (+1.85), *democracy* (+0.39), and *unification* (+0.28). *Territory* sits at zero (+0.03). Two move the other way: *state* (−0.69) and *liberation* (−1.64). We read the six expanders as

legitimation-aligned (Figure 3, left panel). Under *kukchǒngje*, the regime-aligned vocabulary concentrates in a handful of state-authored middle school texts written for the 4th and 5th national curricula in the 1980s. The most consequential single book is **ta_m42** (1981, middle school 4th-curriculum), which scores +6.67 on the Independence axis and anchors the Independence, Nation, History, and Citizens shifts at the per-book level (Appendix H). Of the six, the four largest (*independence, citizens, nation, history*) hold up under the book-level bootstrap. *Democracy* and *unification* sit near chance and read as small positive shifts inside the broader cluster.

Authoritarian rule predates the 1973 reform by more than a decade, so what changes at this boundary is the authorship arrangement. Inside the Authoritarian period, the Chun sub-era (1980–87) does more of the regime-aligned widening than the Yushin sub-era (1973–79). The 1981 and 1987 middle school texts extend the vocabulary further than the 1973 Yushin volumes that introduced *kukchǒngje* (Appendix H.2). The strongest signal arrives several years after the 1973 reform, so we read the *kukchǒngje*-era reorganization as cumulative across its first two curriculum cycles rather than as an instantaneous break.

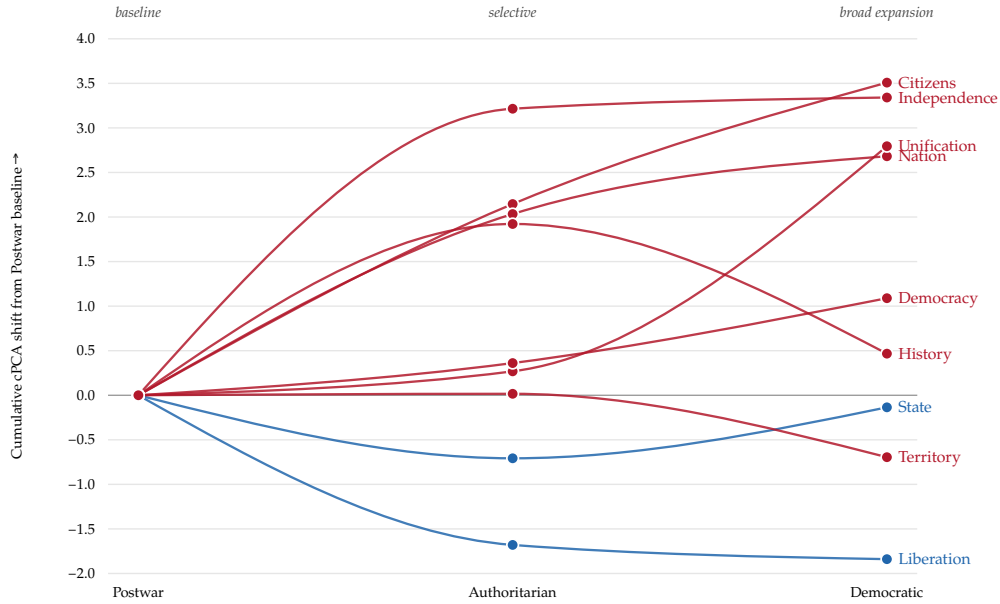


Figure 4: Cumulative cPCA displacement across the three post-liberation periods.

Note: Each line is one identity term, starting from a common Postwar baseline; the first segment adds the Postwar-to-Authoritarian shift and the second the Authoritarian-to-Democratic shift. Red lines moved with the pooled later-period direction under *kukchǒngje*, blue lines against it. The monopoly-era spread is followed by broad upward convergence after 2002, with two exceptions: *history* flips polarity and *territory* turns negative.

The three largest movements (*independence* +3.26, *citizens* +2.17, *nation* +2.05), with *history* close behind (+1.85), line up with a regime invested in anti-colonial legitimacy and ethnic-national belonging delivered through disciplined citizenship. *Liberation* carries the larger of the two negative shifts (−1.64) and fails to widen (SD ratio 0.99), the only term to move against the pooled direction without widening (Section 5 returns to it), while *state* registers a negative centroid but still widens (SD ratio 1.21). *Territory* stays put on the centroid while widening like the rest (SD ratio 1.31). This is selective state appropriation under monopoly authorship (Figure 4). Vocabulary the state could use to legitimate itself widened along the cPCA direction, and content it could not use did not.

Citizens picked up new associations with state-directed citizenship, above all through repeated invocations of the *National Education Charter*.

Nation carries one of the strongest signals (+2.05). Postwar textbooks framed nation in

relatively abstract pedagogical terms, linking national history to patriotism and self-reflective moral cultivation. Authoritarian-era textbooks held onto that didactic function and pushed the term into a broader discourse of colonial victimization stretched into ethnic continuity and historical grievance.

Two sentences pulled from the extreme ends of the contrastive axis make the shift concrete. Postwar textbooks usually framed *nation* in abstract pedagogical terms:

국사 교육은 우리 민족의 과거 생활을 정확하게 인식시켜 자아를 반성하고 애국심과 자주 정신을 함양하는데 중요한 의의와 목적이 있는 것이다.

“National history education has important significance and purpose in accurately recognizing our nation’s past life, fostering self-reflection, and cultivating patriotism and the spirit of self-reliance.”

Authoritarian-era textbooks extended the term into a more concrete vocabulary of colonial grievance and ethnic victimization:

1910년 이후의 일제의 식민지 지배는 우리 민족의 민족 운동을 탄압하고, 경제적 착취를 강행하며, 한국 사회와 문화를 해체시켰다.

“Japan’s colonial rule after 1910 suppressed our nation’s nationalist movement, enforced economic exploitation, and dismantled Korean society and culture.” (1981)

The shift here is an expansion in sentence contexts that now span colonial critique alongside ethnic solidarity and political legitimacy. *Independence* follows a parallel arc. Postwar textbooks frame independence in concrete military-historical terms (the armed Manchurian independence movement under Yu Insŏk and Hong Pŏmdo, 1963), while authoritarian-era textbooks extend it into institutional reform discourse (the Independence Club’s establishment of an independent state through “the people’s power,” 1987). Put differently, independence vocabulary broadens from armed struggle into sovereignty and state-building.

Unification (+0.28) and *democracy* (+0.39) register small, bootstrap-fragile positive shifts. The *democracy* Authoritarian-to-Democratic shift is the only sign-flip in the analysis under drop-one-book resampling, conditional on a single 1987 elementary text (ta_e52; Appendices H.7, H.1). *Unification* stays confined to safe historical references (Unified Silla) and formulaic invocations of reunification, kept from any substantive policy discourse.

Democratization in two waves

The Authoritarian-to-Democratic transition widens an inherited ethnonational vocabulary in two waves. The widening keeps the vocabulary’s ethnic core in place, and each wave arrives with a change in the curriculum system.

Consider 1987 first. The political transition itself coincides with no observable expansion in the discourse. Books from the 5th curriculum and the 5th-to-6th transition that bracket 1987 carry small or negative shifts in Figure 5 rather than positive expansions on the Authoritarian-to-Democratic axis. Democratization arrived in 1987, but *kukchǒngje* persisted, and the textbooks went on reading like the late-authoritarian corpus.

A first wave shows up in the 6th curriculum (1992–97), still under *kukchǒngje*. Five terms register positive per-curriculum deltas at the 6th step on the Authoritarian-to-Democratic axis: *unification* (+1.37), *citizens* (+1.27), *state* (+1.03), *independence* (+1.00), and *nation* (+0.80). Two state-authored modern history volumes carry this (ta_h62, ta_m62). The same institution that produced the late-authoritarian *kukchǒngje* texts was now, under a democratic government, authoring more expansive identity discourse five years before any change in who wrote it.

That arrives with the 2002 *kǒmjǒngje* reform, in a second and broader wave. Its biggest cPCA expansion belongs to *unification* (+2.53), concentrated almost entirely in the 2002–2007 *Han’guk kǔnhyǒndaesa* series of independent-publisher high school textbooks, which pulled contemporary inter-Korean policy vocabulary (Sunshine Policy framings, the June 15 Joint Declaration) into national history education (Appendix H). Six of nine terms register positive per-curriculum deltas at the 7th step, carried by five different publishers (Kǔmsǒng 금성, Tusan 두산, Pǒmmunsa 법문사, Chungang Kyoyuk Chinhǔng 중앙교육진흥, and Tæhan Kyogwasǒ 대한교과서) rather than a single state author: *unification* (+2.32), *liberation* (+1.59), *nation* (+0.92), *history* (+0.70), *citizens* (+0.40), and *independence* (+0.05), with context distributions widening across the transition (SD ratios 1.01–1.31, Appendix H.5). Two terms shift against the dominant democratic direction (*history* –1.45, *territory* –0.71)

while still widening on the SD measure, because their new contexts sit in directions the bulk of democratic-era books do not occupy. We develop the *territory* case next.

Figure 5 shows the two-wave pattern. The discursive opening lands on the curriculum system’s schedule, a first wave in the 6th-curriculum modern history volumes under continuing *kukchǒngje* and a broader one at the 2002 textbook system reform. It does not land at the 1987 political transition. From political democratization to the first observable discursive opening, the lag is roughly five years. To the structural authorship pluralization that coincides with the broader second wave it is fifteen.

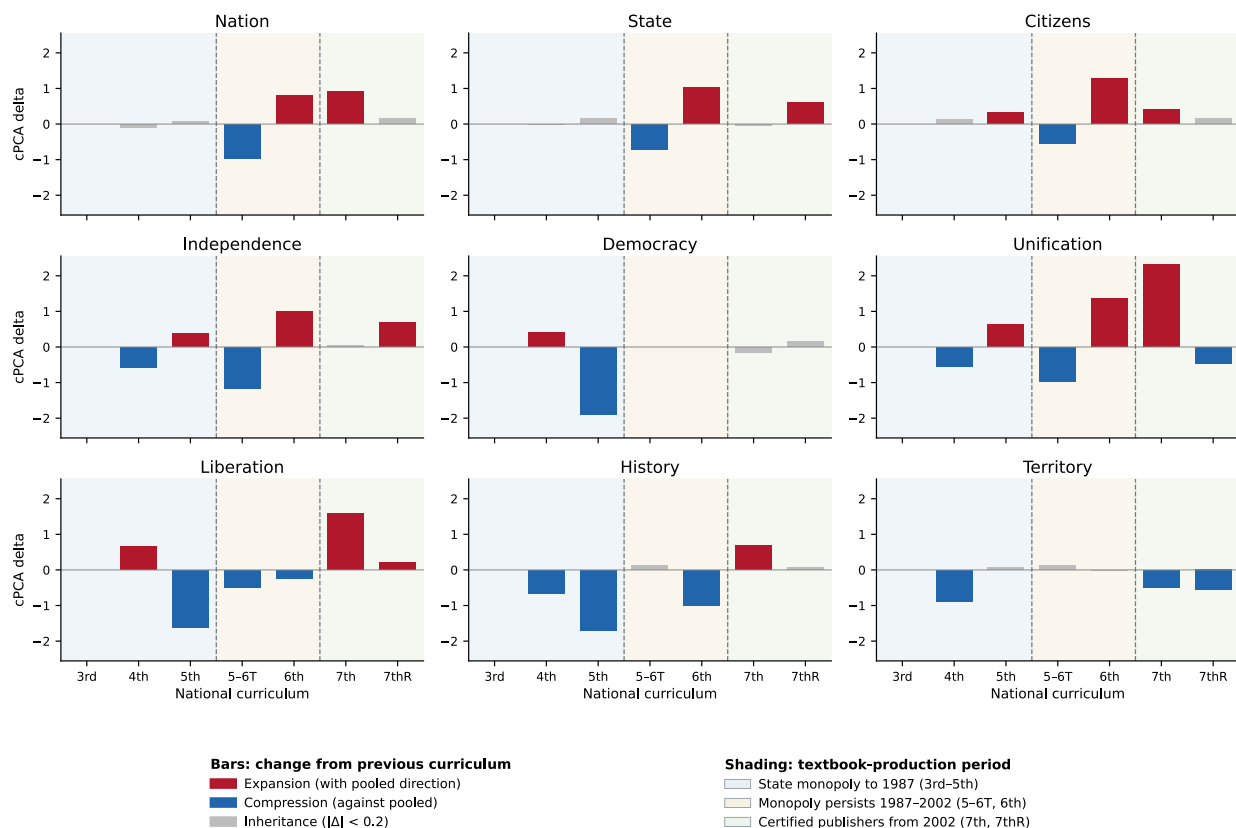


Figure 5: Per-curriculum change on the Authoritarian-to-Democratic axis.

Note: Each bar is the change in a term’s sentence-weighted mean cPCA position from the previous curriculum. The x-axis runs over the post-1973 national curricula in order, where 5-6T denotes volumes published between the 5th and 6th curricula and 7thR the 7th Revised curriculum. Bar colors and the background shading for the three textbook-production periods are explained in the legend; dashed rules mark the 1987 transition and the 2002 authorship reform. The first wave sits at the 6th curriculum and the larger second wave at the 2002 reform.

Unification is the informative case. Under authoritarianism its usage stays restricted to historical references and ritualized formulas:

민족적 숙원인 국토 통일을 위하여 공산주의와 대결할 수 있는 실력 배양에 전력을 집중한다.

“Concentrate all efforts on cultivating the strength to confront communism for the territorial unification that is the nation’s aspiration.” (1973)

After the 2002 *kŏmjŏngje* reform it expands into contemporary policy discourse:

정상 회담 결과 통일 문제와 남북 관계의 기본 방향을 담은 6·15 남북 공동 선언이 발표되었다.

“As a result of the summit, the June 15 Joint Declaration was announced, containing the basic direction for the unification issue and inter-Korean relations.” (2016)

Unification was never short of referents. Monopoly authorship had kept its usage range narrow, and under democracy it widened.

Nation (transition-level shift +0.65) keeps expanding under democratization, though less dramatically than under authoritarianism. The semantic field the authoritarian period built up around ethnic nationalism and colonial grievance carried straight into the democratic corpus and then broadened into the language of divided-nation politics and inter-Korean reconciliation. The 2006 framing of the July 4, 1972 Joint Statement illustrates the move:

7·4 남북 공동 성명에서 남북한은 자주 통일, 평화 통일, 민족 대단결의 3대 원칙을 내세웠다.

“In the July 4 Joint Declaration, North and South Korea put forward three principles of self-reliant reunification, peaceful reunification, and great national unity.” (2006)

The ethnonational frame is not displaced. “Great national unity” (*minjok taedan’gyŏl*) carries its ethnic substrate forward. What changes is the use, as democratic-era textbooks deploy *nation* in the vocabulary of inter-Korean reconciliation and not only in colonial-grievance narratives. Across the post-2002 *nation* corpus, roughly 25% of sentences carry explicit ethnic-community markers (*our nation* [*uri minjok*], *the Korean people* [*hanminjok*], *compatriots* [*tongp’o*], *unitary nation* [*tanil minjok*]) and under 1% contain civic or multi-ethnic markers (*multiethnic* [*taminjok*], *multicultural* [*tamunhwa*], *citizenship* [*siminkwŏn*],

migrants [ijumin], *foreigners* [oegugin]), a conservative lower bound on ethnonational framing (see methods). The 2002 and 2006 high school prefaces still give the curriculum’s purpose as establishing *national identity* (minjok chŏngch’esŏng). Civic notes such as *world citizen* (segye simin) appear alongside *nation* pride rather than in place of it. Democratic-era *nation* usage is a widened ethnonationalism.

Each of the other terms changes differently. *Independence* had already expanded under authoritarianism and shifts only slightly under democracy (+0.13, 1.18-fold widening). *History* expanded under authoritarianism (+1.85) but reverses on the dominant democratic direction (−1.45) while still widening on the SD measure. An effective-dimensionality measure flags an authoritarian-era reorganization onto fewer principal directions that the cPCA axis does not surface (Appendix H.6). *State* drifts into comparative and international contexts (+0.57, ratio 1.31). *Liberation* barely budes (−0.16, SD ratio 1.18) and its authoritarian-era cPCA position is not reversed, an asymmetry we develop in Section 5.

Territory and the post-2002 Dokdo discourse

Territory cuts against this pattern. Across the Postwar and Authoritarian periods it sits inside a pre-modern dynastic-territorial framing built around Goguryeo expansion and Manchurian heritage, and around state-formation through territorial consolidation, with the two periods using nearly identical vocabulary (cPCA centroid moves only −0.04). Authoritarian textbooks did treat territory in international terms, but within Cold War and non-aligned framings of sovereignty rather than bilateral disputes. The Authoritarian-to-Democratic transition then introduces a different discourse, folding Dokdo and Northeast-Asian bilateral disputes directly into national history education:

독도는 울릉도에 딸린 섬으로서, 일찍부터 우리 나라의 영토로 이어져 내려왔다.

“Dokdo, an island attached to Ulleungdo, has been our country’s territory from early times onward.” (H-1 (1, 2006), 2006)

For *territory* the cPCA centroid shift is small and not individually robust (the −0.71 Authoritarian-

to-Democratic value has a bootstrap interval crossing zero; Appendix H.7), so the evidence for an added discourse rests on the corpus counts rather than the axis. Those counts are unambiguous. Pre-modern dynastic-territorial usage persists while bilateral-dispute and Dokdo-specific vocabulary accumulates on top. The corpus-level escalation is steep. Mean counts of 독도 (Dokdo) per book climb from 0.15 in the pre-3rd-curriculum books to roughly 2 in the 3rd–6th curricula, then 10.7 in the 7th and 40 in the 7th Revised (0.78 per book averaged across everything published before 1987; Figure 6), with two post-2008 volumes (H-57, H-54) carrying 77 and 57 mentions each. Across the post-2002 *territory* corpus, 13% of sentences name Dokdo directly, rising to one in five in the 7th Revised volumes, against 2% carrying any civic or multiethnic marker. The escalation coincides with exogenous bilateral shocks, the 2005 Shimane Prefecture “Takeshima Day” declaration and successive Japanese textbook revisions (Nozaki, 2008), which we cannot separate from it. What the 2002 *kŏmjŏngje* shift did was make it institutionally possible to fold contemporary territorial-dispute content into the curriculum. The post-2002 addition to *territory* is a heightened-sovereignty frame, not a civic-territorial alternative.

↑ Mean 독도 (Dokdo) mentions per textbook

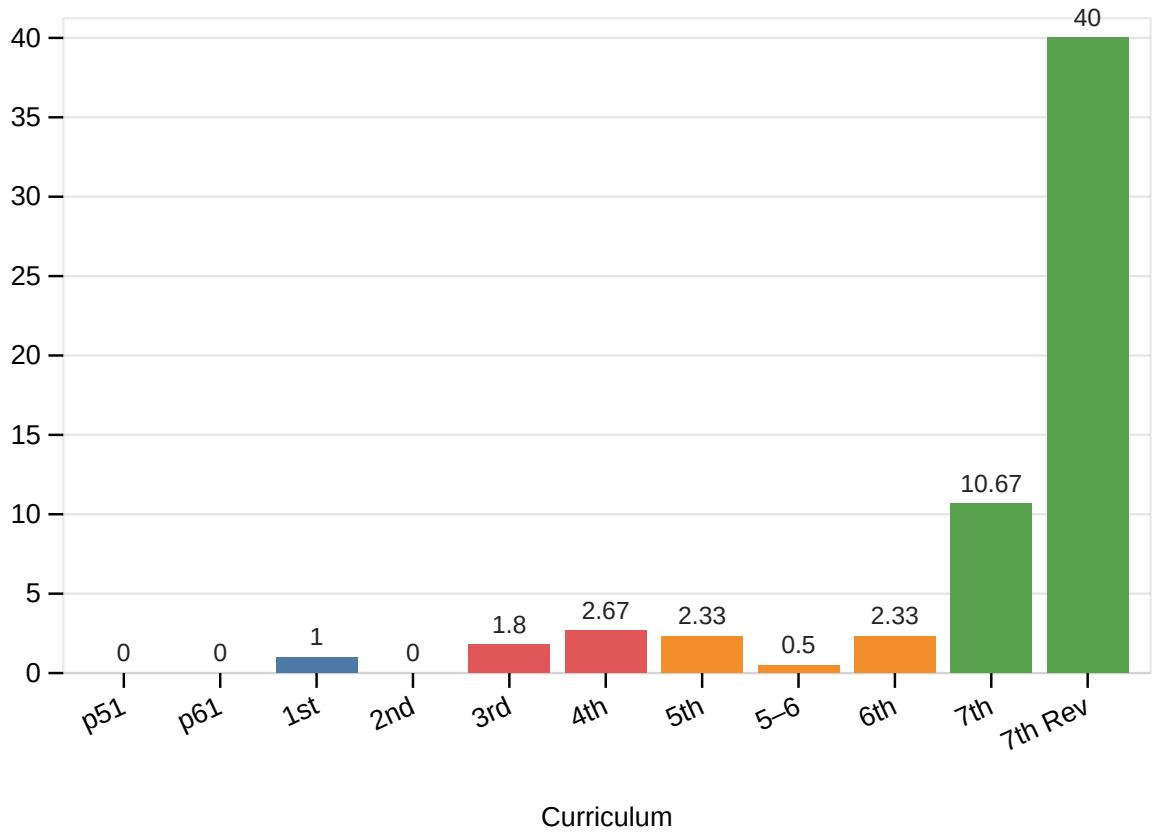


Figure 6: Dokdo mentions per textbook by national curriculum.

Note: Mean count of 독도 (Dokdo) mentions per book, 1946–2016, colored by the authorship arrangement in force. The escalation concentrates in the post-2002 *kŏmjŏngje* books, rising from 10.7 mentions per book in the 7th curriculum (2002–07) to 40 in the 7th Revised (2007 onward), a window that also contains exogenous Korea–Japan disputes (see main text).

Taken together, where authoritarian-era textbooks show selective widening and constraint, the post-2002 *kŏmjŏngje* corpus carries new discourses (bilateral territorial dispute, contemporary inter-Korean policy) that authoritarian *kukchŏngje* textbooks had excluded, while keeping the older ones in place. The democratic-era corpus widens the surface of identity discourse while its ethnonational core stays in place.

Why liberation moved differently

Liberation fails to widen on the cPCA axis under authoritarianism (SD ratio 0.99) while its centroid moves substantially against the pooled direction (−1.64), the only term to combine

the two. This is not compression. Trace ratios of period-conditional covariances fall inside $[0.95, 1.07]$ across all 18 cells (Appendix H.6), and the small Postwar sample ($N = 73$) puts the SD ratio near the noise floor of a statistic biased above 1 by construction. The asymmetry is on the cPCA direction, not overall semantic range.

What the cPCA axis captures is the dual meaning of *liberation*, between premodern slave emancipation and post-1945 national liberation. Authoritarian-era textbooks concentrated their cPCA-distinctive usage on the slave-emancipation sense, marking Chosŏn-era social reform:

사회 분야에서는 계급 타파, 노비 해방 등 신분 제도를 철폐하고, 조혼을 금지하는 한편 과부의 재혼을 허가하였으며, 의복 제도를 간소화시켰다.

“In the social sphere, class was abolished, slaves were liberated and the status system dismantled, early marriage was prohibited, the remarriage of widows permitted, and the dress code simplified.” (ta_m31, 1973)

The post-1945 sense persists at the opposite end of the same axis, in commemorative form (“민족의 해방과 독립을 기약” [pledging the nation’s liberation and independence], ta_h31 1973), but does not anchor the cPCA-distinctive direction. Under democratization the centroid shows no detectable directional change on this axis (-0.16 , with a bootstrap interval of $[-1.25, +1.77]$ and an unstable sign; Appendix H.7), while the distribution widens modestly (SD ratio 1.18). Across all nine terms, *liberation* traces the most clearly asymmetric trajectory. It shows substantial, sign-stable centroid movement under authoritarianism without widening, then no detectable centroid change under democracy.

Summary

Variance changes dominate both post-liberation transitions. Terms widened or narrowed their contexts while their core reference held.

For Postwar-to-Authoritarian the change is selective. Six concepts moved with the dominant *kukchŏngje* direction (*independence, citizens, nation, history, democracy, unification*), *territory* sat at zero, and two moved against it (*state, liberation*). The four largest hold up

under book-level resampling, anchored by *ta_m42* (1981) and the Chun sub-era more than by the 1973 Yushin texts.

Democratic-era change arrives in two waves on the production system’s schedule. The 1987 transition coincided with no observable shift. A first wave appears in the 6th curriculum (1992–97) under continuing *kukchǒngje*, so the democratic regime shows in the language while the state still wrote the books. A broader second wave arrives with the 2002 *kǒmjǒngje* reform, anchored by the independent-publisher *Han’guk kǔnhyǒndaesa* series (Figure 5).

What expands under democracy extends the inherited ethnonational vocabulary rather than displacing it. *Unification* takes on contemporary inter-Korean policy content (6·15 Joint Declaration, Sunshine Policy) folded inside a *national community* (*minjok kongdongch’e*) framing, and *territory* takes on the Dokdo sovereignty discourse, with mean mentions of 독도 (Dokdo) per book rising from 0.78 before 1987 to 40 in the 7th Revised curriculum. This is not the civic-territorial reframing found in Taiwan (Chen et al., 2023; Ho, 2022).

The authoritarian-era asymmetry is only partially undone. *Liberation* fails to widen under *kukchǒngje* (SD ratio 0.99) while moving against the pooled direction, and widens only modestly under democracy (1.18).

The result is layered. Regime type shows in the character and content of change, selective appropriation under the monopoly and broad ethnonational widening under democracy. The production institutions set the timing and reach, in 1973, 1992, and 2002, and not at 1987. Regime change reached the narrative through the institutions that wrote it.

6 Discussion and Conclusion

Across 67 South Korean *kuksa* textbooks spanning 1895–2016, regime type and the institutional arrangement that produces the national narrative separate conceptually and empirically. Each leaves its own signature in identity discourse. Regime type shows in the character and content of change, and the production arrangement in its timing and scale.

The four transitions our corpus covers combine the two parameters in different ways. The 1945 colonial-to-postwar break joined regime and institutional change, and the vocabulary reordered more than at any other point in the timeline. The 1973 *kukchǒngje* consolidation changed institutions inside authoritarianism, and its imprint was selective, consistent with monopoly authorship. The 1987 transition changed regime without changing institutions, and shows no detectable change. The 1992 curriculum revision and the 2002 authorship reform were institutional changes that occurred within democracy, first at the level of the curriculum cycle and later at the level of the authorship system. The post-1987 widening arrives precisely at these two moments.

The asymmetry around the 1987 transition carries the greatest interpretive weight. For fifteen years, a democratic state authored the national history textbook through institutional machinery inherited from an authoritarian regime. The language did not change at the democratic transition itself. Instead, it changed in two waves tied to curriculum-system institutions. The first emerged in the 6th-curriculum modern history volumes produced under continuing *kukchǒngje* (1992–97), where the new democratic government’s remit became visible in books the state still wrote. The second, broader wave followed the introduction of the post-2002 *Han’guk kŭnhyŏndaesa* series after authorship shifted to certified publishers. What the words were permitted to mean changed when the institutions producing them changed, first through the curriculum and then through the authorship system. Strikingly, this occurred in *kuksa*, the part of the curriculum least open to revision.

We interpret this pattern through Jo (2025)’s account of national identity transitions, which attributes them to the work of “storytelling elites,” the actors authorized to define the nation in public discourse. Our corpus extends Jo’s framework into a broader argument about institutional arrangement. The relevant parameter is the number of actors authorized to produce the national narrative. Changes in that number are reflected in the discursive surface under authoritarian and democratic regimes alike, while the regime in power governs what that change carries.

The 1973 consolidation contracted the field to a single authorizing body within an otherwise unchanged regime. The 2002 reform expanded authorship in modern history within an already democratic one. The timing and scale of the discursive changes track these changes in authorship structure, while their content reflects the governments in power. Under Park, reorganization supported anti-colonial legitimation and disciplined citizenship. Under democratic governments, widening carried themes of reconciliation and sovereignty disputes. The 1992 wave occupies an intermediate position: a curriculum revision within an unchanged authorship system, where the new government's remit shows in the content without introducing new authors.

Monopoly authorship is associated with a selective pattern of change. Six terms moved in the pooled *kukchǒngje* direction, *territory* remained effectively unchanged, and two terms moved against it. On the separate widening measure, seven of the nine terms widened, while *independence* and *liberation* remained stable. Distributed authorship, by contrast, coincides with broad widening across the inherited vocabulary. This division of labor is falsifiable. Had discourse shifted at the 1987 transition itself, or remained flat through the 2002 reform, the argument would fail.

Liberation provides the clearest example of how pedagogical fit and political risk aligned under monopoly authorship. One meaning, referring to slave emancipation, fit the state's modernization narrative as a story of internal Korean social progress. The other, referring to post-1945 national liberation, foregrounded colonial rule and required a contested account of independence to enter the curriculum. Monopoly authorship constrained *liberation* to the narrower meaning rather than allowing its contextual range to widen. The institutional arrangement therefore governed which meanings an already familiar lexical item could acquire. After 2002, distributed authorship allowed the inherited *nation* frame to extend into new contexts without displacing it.

The content of this widening matters as much as its timing, and it is here that regime type appears most clearly. The widening extends the ethnonational frame rather than replacing

it. In post-2002 textbooks, approximately 25

The comparison with Taiwan highlights the divergence. We invoke it as comparative evidence rather than as data under our control. Chen et al. (2023) show that Taiwan’s 1997 curriculum reform, which recentered textbooks on Taiwan rather than China, shifted students away from Chinese ethnonational identification and toward a civic, island-centered identity. Ho (2022) traces the same delinking from pan-Han nationalism within the curriculum itself. Korea’s opening after 2002 saw no comparable transformation. The vocabulary widened, but the community it named remained ethnic and cultural, defined through descent and the orientation that Jo (2025) identifies as deeply embedded in South Korea’s grand narrative, even as Taiwan’s storytelling elites remade theirs.

This contrast fits the directional condition implied by our argument. Taiwan possessed a politically viable alternative referent, whether ‘Chinese’ or ‘Taiwanese,’ giving pluralized authorship material with which to redirect the story. In Korea, *nation* remained largely uncontested across the regime divide, while the reality of a divided peninsula preserved the usefulness of ethnonational unification discourse for democratic governments. The institutional arrangement that produces the textbook governs when discourse can change. The regime in power, together with the alternative identities available to it, governs the direction of that change. The asymmetric authoritarian pattern is also consistent with Tetteh and Edgell (2026)’s cross-national finding that autocratic educational indoctrination is associated with weaker pro-democracy attitudes and stronger regime-compatible mobilization. Although the outcome domain differs, the implication points in the same direction.

A distinction between vocabulary and meaning runs throughout our interpretation. The same nine identity terms appear across every stage of the corpus from 1895 to 2016. The first and largest institutional rupture, the post-1945 reordering, established the modern lexicon of Korean nationhood as textbook vocabulary inherited by successor regimes. This is the form of layered institutional change described by Mahoney and Thelen (2010): a stable core that persists while later regimes attach new uses to it. What changes across regimes is not

the vocabulary itself, but the distribution of contexts in which those words appear. It is the textbook counterpart to the durable narrative templates that Wertsch (2002) identifies beneath changing official histories. Post-2002 *kŏmjŏngje* textbooks invoke *unification* in contemporary inter-Korean policy discourse and place *territory* within the Dokdo dispute frame alongside older usages rather than instead of them. Survey-experimental work involving one of us finds substantially stronger identity-conformity pressures in South Korea, where state-authored textbook traditions remained uniform for longer (Denney et al., 2026). From a different empirical tradition, those findings are consistent with the pattern we observe here.

The analytical pipeline also makes a methodological contribution. It identifies substantively relevant concepts in domain-specific text without relying on a researcher-constructed keyword list. Four 32B-class language models trained within distinct traditions extract identity-related nouns, and we retain only those selected by at least three of the four. BERTopic independently identifies all nine terms and LDA identifies five, suggesting convergence across methods. The resulting analytical vocabulary is therefore grounded in the corpus rather than in our priors. Sentence-embedding semantic axes (cPCA, Procrustes, and logistic regression) then track shifts in the contextual distributions of those terms, reaching aspects of change that curated keyword lists and frequency counts cannot capture (Appendices A, D).

Several measurement limitations qualify how far these claims can travel. We analyze an observational corpus of $N = 67$ textbooks and cannot identify the causal effect of any individual reform. We measure textbook language rather than how students interpreted it. Sentence embeddings capture distributional context rather than meaning in a stronger philosophical sense, and the encoder was not trained on pre-1980s or hanja-mixed orthography. Stripping hanja and re-embedding reproduces all nine cPCA signs across both transitions, and restricting the semantic analyses to the post-liberation corpus confines them to a single writing system (Appendix H.4). The cleaned GEI OCR also contains no more residual non-content characters than the digital NIKH texts, although we did not compute a gold-standard

character error rate.

Three analytical limitations bear directly on our central separation claim, and we address them empirically rather than treating them as assumptions (Appendix H.4 and the Methods). The weakest link concerns the interpretation of 1987 as a moment of “no change.” Because cPCA magnitude is partly mechanical, we place greater weight on signals that the placebo exercise cannot manufacture: per-term sign concordance, the discriminative axis, and the curriculum-level timing. Pooled-sentence cross-validation accuracy reaches 0.72–0.75 at the institutional transitions but only 0.65 at the 1987 boundary, just above the 0.60 value obtained from an arbitrary within-period split. We therefore interpret 1987 not as a proven null, but as the least discriminable boundary among the plausible candidates.

A second limitation is that the post-2002 wave is confounded with the inclusion of the *Han’guk kŭnhyŏndaesa* genre. The *kuksa*-only sensitivity analysis suggests that its magnitude should be attributed jointly to the *kŏmjŏngje* reform and to genre. A third limitation concerns heterogeneity within the democratic period. We report it at the curriculum level rather than the publisher level because several curriculum cycles contain only one or two publishers. Finally, our interpretation of *liberation* remains cautious given the small Postwar sample ($N = 73$).

A note on direction is also warranted. The timing of the shifts, each arriving with an institutional reform rather than at the 1987 regime transition, is suggestive of a causal relationship, though we read it as suggestive rather than established. We interpret the relationship as running from institutions to language rather than the reverse because the 1973 decree, the 1992 curriculum revision, and the 2002 reform are administrative acts that precede the textbooks produced under them. The reverse arrow, however, is not implausible. Textbook content and the conflicts surrounding it can themselves prompt institutional reform, as illustrated by the *kŭnhyŏndaesa* controversies and the 2015 effort to restore a state-authored textbook. Over longer time horizons, institutions and narratives likely shape one another. Our claims concern where and when language change appears, and the obser-

vational design cannot rule out more subtle forms of feedback. With no exogenous variation in authorship and only a single national case, we present the pattern as consistent with, not proof of, institutional causation.

Two extensions follow most directly from these limitations. First, comparing *kuksa* with more flexible subjects such as *sahoe* or ethics would test whether national history is indeed the slowest-moving part of the curriculum. Second, a reception study linking the corpus to cohort surveys could assess whether these changes in textbook language altered how students understood nationhood.

7 Data availability

The replication package (analysis code, the merged corpus metadata, and the derived intermediate files needed to regenerate every table and figure) is available at [archive DOI to be assigned]. The single script `10_reproduce_main_results.py` regenerates Table 2, the per-term cross-validated accuracies, and the cPCA standard deviation ratios from the committed sentence embeddings. The committed intermediate CSVs allow all main-text numbers to be re-rendered without a GPU, while regenerating the sentence embeddings themselves requires a CUDA-capable GPU. Two corpus sources carry redistribution constraints. NIKH digital-archive texts are included under research-use provisions, and for the post-2002 commercially published textbooks the package distributes only derived quantities (sentence-level embeddings, term counts, and axis projections) rather than the underlying `full_text`. Raw page images are not redistributed.

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